

Gauguin

Famous for leaving his stockbroking job in Paris, abandoning his family and moving to Tahiti, Paul Gauguin (1848–1903), discarded all respectability to become an artist at the age of 35. Influenced by Pissarro, he participated in the last four Impressionist exhibitions, and during visits to Pont-Aven in Brittany developed a style he called Synthetism. In 1888–89, he worked briefly with Van Gogh in the South of France, but in 1891 he left France for Tahiti, where he produced many of his most famous paintings, sculptures and woodcuts. He spent most of the rest of his life in the South Seas.

One of the first artists to find inspiration in the art of primitive cultures, he invented a non-naturalistic painting style of strong outlines and bright, flat colour, combining influences from medieval stained glass and Polynesian, Buddhist, Asiatic, ancient Greek and folk art, to Impressionism and Realism. Both the Nabis and the Symbolist movement were shaped by his ideas, although he personally rejected the concepts of Symbolism.



Gauguin, *Tahitian Women on the Beach*, 1891